

A Scattering of British Types

This decade saw efforts to make aviation more affordable, with a growth in kit aircraft and the arrival of hang-glider-based microlights. Composites were used for fuselage and wing construction and engine tuning was enhanced. At the other end of the market, specialized aircraft such as the Voyager appeared and luxury aircraft were pressurized.



◁ Piper PA-32R-301T Turbo Saratoga 1980

Origin USA

Engine 300hp Lycoming IO-540-K1G5 turbocharged flat-6

Top speed 215 mph (346 km/h)

Designed in the 1970s as a high-performance personal six-seater, popular with businessmen and air taxi services, this Piper was updated in 1980 as the Turbo Saratoga and was built up to 2009.



◁ Piper PA-46 Malibu 1982

Origin USA

Engine 310hp Teledyne Continental Motors TSIO-520BE turbocharged flat-6

Top speed 269 mph (433 km/h)

One of the first pressurized six-seaters, the Malibu was designed to give a range of 1,550 nautical miles (2,871km). After costly engine failures it was replaced by the Lycoming-engined Malibu Mirage.



△ Slingsby T67A Firefly 1981

Origin UK

Engine 120hp Lycoming O-235-L2A air-cooled flat-4

Top speed 130 mph (209 km/h)

René Fournier first flew his RF-6 in 1974 and built it in France until 1981, when he sold the design to Slingsby, whose aerobatic training aircraft has proved popular with the US, British, and other armed forces.



◁ Cessna 172Q Cutlass 1983

Origin USA

Engine 180hp Lycoming O-360-A4N air-cooled flat-4

Top speed 140 mph (225 km/h)

A supremely practical and inexpensive four-seater, the 172 is the world's highest production aircraft, with over 43,000 built. The more powerful 172Q was slightly faster than the standard model.

▷ Rutan Voyager 1984

Origin USA

Engine 130hp Teledyne Continental O-240/110hp Teledyne Continental IO-200

Top speed 122 mph (196 km/h)

Conceived by three enthusiasts and built by volunteers, this ultralight (2,251 lb/1,021 kg unladen) aircraft made the first nonstop flight around the world, covering 26,366 miles (42,432 km) in nine days.



△ Beechcraft A36 Bonanza 1987

Origin USA

Engine 300hp Continental IO-550-BB air-cooled flat-6

Top speed 203 mph (326 km/h)

Considered by many to be the Rolls-Royce of light aircraft, the beautifully built Bonanza first flew in 1945. It continued in production in the form of the 1980s' A36, which had a fuselage stretched by 10 in (25 cm) and a conventional tailplane.

